human overlords didn't anticipate. This can result in dangerous unforeseen consequences that are not aligned with the original human goals. Even if recommendation algorithms stop encouraging hate, other instances of the alignment problem might result in larger catastrophes than the anti-Rohingya campaign. The more powerful and independent computers become, the bigger the danger.

Of course, the alignment problem is neither new nor unique to algorithms. It bedevilled humanity for thousands of years before the invention of computers. It has been, for example, the foundational problem of modern military thinking, enshrined in Carl von Clausewitz's theory of war. Clausewitz was a Prussian general who fought during the Napoleonic Wars. Following Napoleon's final defeat in 1815, Clausewitz became the director of the Prussian War College. He also began formalising a grand theory of war. After he died of cholera in 1831, his wife, Marie, edited his unfinished manuscript and published *On War* in several parts between 1832 and 1834.[22]

On War created a rational model for understanding war, and it is still the dominant military theory today. Its most important maxim is that 'war is the continuation of policy by other means'.[23] This implies that war is not an emotional outbreak, a heroic adventure or a divine punishment. War is not even a military phenomenon. Rather, war is a political tool. According to Clausewitz, military actions are utterly irrational unless they are aligned with some overarching political goal.

Suppose Mexico contemplates whether to invade and conquer its small neighbour Belize. And suppose a detailed military analysis concludes that if the Mexican army invades, it will achieve a quick and decisive military victory, crushing the small Belize army and conquering the capital, Belmopan, in three days. According to Clausewitz, that does not constitute a rational reason for Mexico to invade. The mere ability to secure military victory is meaningless. The key question the Mexican government should ask itself is, what political goals will the military success achieve?

History is full of decisive military victories that led to political disasters. For Clausewitz, the most obvious example was close to home: Napoleon's career. Nobody disputes the military genius of Napoleon, who was a master of both tactics and strategy. But while his string of victories brought Napoleon temporary control of vast territories, they failed to secure lasting political achievements. His military conquests merely drove most European